

locals clashed with them while grabbing forest land at the behest of Naxalites of the People's War Group (PWG) who had infiltrated from Gadchiroli in Maharashtra. The conflict is the same old tale but with a special initiative of the Government, the locals have dumped the Naxalite influence and are now looking ahead.

**T**oday, the dairy centre at Kosimda collects a litre of milk each from 150 families of the village and sends it to the Sumul dairy in Surat, providing income to the villagers. It also has 17 borewells, 35 open wells and a school up to Class VII with computers. Outmigration from the village in search of jobs has come down substantially. The villagers used to grow only millets, but now have flowing fields of pulses. A small reservoir caters to the crop. Not just Kosimda, almost all 311 villages in Dang have 24-hour power. Over 700 check dams in the district ensure water for the district. Till the mid-'90s, the dairy industry was almost unknown in Dang, where the cattle quality is poor. Today, it collects 30,000 litres of milk a day. At Rs 15 a litre, sales translate into Rs 4.5 lakh per day.

Says Bachubhai Gavit, 36, who



**THE DAIRY CENTRE AT KOSIMDA**



**“Earlier we lived a wretched existence due to lack of jobs. We are much better off now.”**

**ARJUN GAVIT, LOCAL EMPLOYED WITH THE FOREST DEPARTMENT**

heads Kosimda's eco-development committee and the local milk cooperative, “Earlier there were many in the village who used to subsist on wild roots. Today no one goes to bed without two square meals a day.” The only old sign of backwardness is a 2-km mud street snaking into the village from the main road; since a part of it passes through a sanctuary, it is subject to stiff ecological rules.

There has been complete synergy between the bureaucracy and political leadership of Gujarat on Dang. Says Chief Minister Narendra Modi,

“The Dang model is an effective answer to the challenge posed by ultra-left ideologies. We have tried to give a very responsive administration in Dang backed by imaginative welfare schemes.” The reins of Dang have been with its in-charge Secretary S.K. Nanda, an IAS officer who has visited the district over 160 times in 10 years. “The Government has tried to create an atmosphere of hope for the locals, which stops them from falling into the trap of those spreading disaffection. The delivery of public services in Dang is top class,” he says.

The schemes introduced by the state Government aim at the poor tribal population. Every tribal is allowed to cut a specific number of teak trees at regular intervals from the lot owned by him. The Forest Department stands as a guarantor for tribals seeking advance loans against their trees. The Joint Forest Management Committee of Vaghai village runs a canteen for tourists, employing locals. It also backs them in four-tier plantation of wood, fruits, flowers, tubers and roots which they can sell and keep the profits. Says Arjun Gavit, a measurement supervisor at the forest depot at Vaghai, “The situation in Dang is 10 times better than it was in the '90s where we lived a wretched existence due to lack of employment and income.” One of the most powerful bridges today between the Government and the Dang tribals is the Lok Darbar (people's court), where officials meet villagers to address their problems.

Though Dang still figures on the Maoist radar, it has been the collective determination of the locals and government officials that has led the tribals out from the shadows of abject poverty and backwardness and into prosperity. Butter does beat guns in the battleground of development. ■